



WAR AND POSSIBLE PEACE

A portrait of Iran’s supreme leaders hangs at a Tehran mosque during a commemoration for those killed in war. President Trump says he told negotiators to not rush into a deal to end the conflict. **WORLD, A2**

Tentative progress on crisis in O.C.

Official says potential crack in chemical tank may reduce likelihood of a blast or large leak.

By Deborah Netburn, Rong-Gong Lin II and Summer Lin

With evacuation shelters reaching capacity as more than 40,000 people were asked to leave their homes, officials laboring to prevent an explosion at a crippled chemical tank in Garden Grove reported tentative progress Sunday in ending the crisis.

TJ McGovern, interim fire chief for the Orange County Fire Authority, said firefighters had discovered what appeared to be a potential crack on the tank’s surface that could be alleviating some of the pressure resulting from the chemical reaction inside.

If they are right, it would make a catastrophic explosion or an uncontrollable leak less likely.

“With this new information, it could change our trajectory and our strategy to this event,” McGovern said. “This was a step in a right direction, and there’s going to be a lot more coming shortly.”

Lee Zeldin, U.S. Environmental Protection Agency administrator, said the new development was promising.

“I’m being told this morning that the most likely scenario is that the tank is safe.” [See Evacuations, A6]

The horrors underfoot around World Cup site

In the Guadalajara region, hundreds of bodies have been found in clandestine graves

By Steve Fisher | REPORTING FROM MEXICO CITY

The highway from the Guadalajara city airport to downtown is newly paved and the city’s famous roundabout has gotten a \$4-million face-lift. The city is abuzz with renovation projects as Guadalajara prepares to host four World Cup soccer matches in June.

But there’s one thing the 3 million fans expected to flock to the city won’t see — the sites where hundreds of bodies have been found in clandestine graves dug by Mexico’s notorious Jalisco New Generation cartel. Scores were discovered on the main route leading to Akron Stadium, where the games will be played.

One set of remains was that of a 17-year-old high school student who had gone out to sell his motorcycle to help his unemployed uncle. He disappeared. When his uncle began searching, he disappeared as well. At another site, the bones of a 34-year-old cellphone repair-

man were found. He was a father of two who’d simply ventured out to shop for used tennis shoes.

According to statistics compiled by the state of Jalisco, between 2018 and March this year, 1,907 bodies were found in Guadalajara and surrounding cities.

The arrival of the World Cup is an opportunity for Mexico’s second-largest city to shine on the international stage, and the Jalisco state government launched an upbeat campaign highlighting the municipality where games will be played: “Zapopan, the heart of soccer,” the slogan goes.

Families searching for their loved ones sarcastically responded with, “Zapopan, the heart of clandestine graves.”

Since January 2025 alone, search groups and authorities have discovered 58 graves with 226 sets of remains within [See Graves, A4]

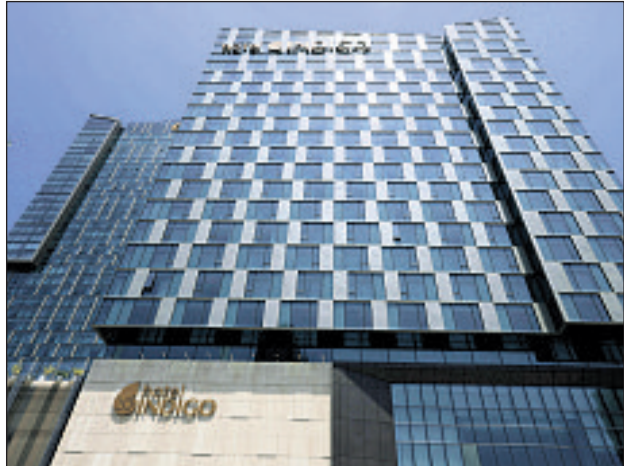


LILIANA MEZA’S son Maximiliano Romero Meza disappeared in 2020.

Hotels yet to see surge from soccer’s big event

World Cup bookings in L.A. and other cities lower than expected

By Caroline Petrow-Cohen



THE EVENT historically has triggered a jump in tourism. Above, Hotel Indigo in downtown L.A.

Hotel rooms in Los Angeles and other FIFA World Cup host cities could sit empty, despite high expectations that the global sporting event would be a boon to the city.

The soccer tournament, which has sold more than 5 million tickets so far, has historically triggered a surge of international and domestic tourism and infused host cities with an economic boost.

This year, however, 80% of hotels surveyed by the American Hotel and Lodging Assn. said bookings are lagging behind initial forecasts. The hotel association partly blames FIFA for the slowdown, saying the organization overbooked blocks of hotel rooms that did not reflect true demand.

Travel also is being hampered by higher airfares and gas prices due to the conflict in Iran. Visa barriers and broader geopolitical concerns are suppressing international travel demand, the report said.

“With just two months [See Hotels, A10]

Experts say bees swarming early

Beekeepers note that a warm winter and dry spring could be making insects more vulnerable. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Angels fans hit a tipping point

Frustration with long-term losing boils over as many call for owner Arte Moreno to sell the team. **SPORTS, D1**

Art collective’s big wow moment

A folk-art fantasia from Everything Is Terrible lands at the new Meow Wolf L.A. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 72/58. **B6**

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Crime fell but remains issue in mayor’s race

Though homicides are way down, Bass’ rivals level attacks over homelessness, drugs.

By Libor Janý

Homicides in Los Angeles are down to levels not seen since the 1960s. Neighborhoods once awash in gang violence now sometimes go weeks, even months, without a shooting. And the follow-home robberies and street take-overs that captured the public’s attention in recent years have largely subsided.

By many measures, the city is safer than it has been in generations — and yet voters following L.A.’s hotly contested mayoral race might think the opposite.

The challengers to Mayor Karen Bass have zeroed in on homelessness and public drug use to argue she hasn’t delivered on public safety, while also criticizing how the Police Department has operated and been funded during her tenure.

Mike Bonin, a former L.A. City Council member, said the fact that Spencer Pratt — the former reality TV star

who has been attacking Bass from the right — has gained so much traction in the race is proof of how Bass and other candidates to the left have failed to change “prevailing narratives that the city is unsafe.”

Pratt has been particularly active on social media, where he has shared artificial-intelligence videos created by fans depicting him as various superheroes coming to the rescue of a city that, under Democratic rule, has turned into a dystopian hellscape.

In a March 26 post on Substack, Pratt railed against the thousands of drug-related calls that emergency officials respond to every month. He has said that if elected mayor, he would order the police and fire chiefs and the county health director to “treat every encampment as a grave-disability zone.”

“No new laws needed,” he wrote. “No endless task forces.”

Flanking Bass on the left is Nithya Raman, a progressive City Council member who was once the mayor’s political ally.

Raman has argued that Bass has thrown too much [See Crime, A7]

Contest for city attorney heats up

Leaked LAPD files, costly lawsuits leave incumbent vulnerable against two rivals.

By Sonja Sharp and James Queally

The Los Angeles city attorney is often described as the most powerful elected official almost no one’s ever heard of.

The office prosecutes most misdemeanor crimes, defends the city against costly lawsuits and serves as the public’s chief lawyer at a time when L.A. faces frequent attacks from a hostile White House. Races for the office tend to be sleepy affairs, but this year’s contest has featured last-minute entrants, a whopping influx of cash and defections among the incumbent’s key supporters.

City Atty. Hydee Feld-

stein Soto’s first term was marked by an explosion in costly litigation against the city and allegations of misconduct and mistreatment of employees. She has denied wrongdoing and defended her record, but now two well-funded opponents are flanking her from different sides of the political spectrum.

The race began to heat up last month after a data breach that saw a massive trove of LAPD records leaked onto the internet. That spurred the city’s police union to withdraw its endorsement of Feldstein Soto and tell its members to vote instead for John McKinney, a Los Angeles County prosecutor who has received a massive influx of corporate cash to support his campaign in recent weeks.

The progressive challenger is Marissa Roy, a deputy attorney general in the California Department of [See City attorney, A7]

Drama becomes public at Riverside City Hall

By Alex Wigglesworth

The letter was remarkable. In an official rebuke of a private citizen, the Riverside City Council accused one of its residents of harassing local employees through phone calls, emails and social media posts.

But even more extraordinary was the fact the letter was addressed to the wife of the city’s chief executive.

“Your pattern of communication has been disruptive at the workplace, caused significant distress to City staff, and serves no legitimate purpose,” read the letter sent to the home of Susan Freeman and her husband, City Manager Mike Futrell.

The Dec. 11 missive is just one of hundreds of emails, texts and letters that have become public recently, shocking residents with accusations of toxic work conditions and “civic indecency” within City Hall. The controversy that has embroiled the prominent Riverside couple has fueled calls for the city manager’s ouster

as well as ignited debate over free speech and workplace boundaries.

“It’s a weird story,” said Jason Hunter, a Riverside resident who posted the letter online after obtaining it through a public records request. “It comes down to: Can somebody’s family member be such a distraction that it increases liability for the city and decreases productivity to the point where you have to let a person go?”

Freeman has denied the allegations, describing them as an unconstitutional attempt to silence her criticism of President Trump and to smear her reputation.

“I did not do one of the things accused in that letter and I can prove that,” she said. “But even if I had, it was still my right.”

The furor marks a surprising turn of fortune for a powerful couple who arrived in Riverside roughly three years ago with impressive resumes.

Futrell is a retired U.S. Navy captain who once [See Riverside, A8]